Alternative explanations of the phenomena that motivate Kratzer

Conditionals

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1. More on semantic mismatch

The proponent of semantic mismatch thinks that in the examples, the most natural readings for the embedded modals (and conditionals? and attitude verbs?) embedded in the consequents of conditionals is different from the most natural readings for the same words when unembedded.

Q1: is there a *possible* reading of the unembedded modal sentence that's the same as the reading that's natural for the consequent of the conditional?

Q2: is there a *possible* reading of the conditional where its consequent has the reading that's natural for the unembedded modal sentence?

- If the answer to both questions was 'no', it's unclear what we even mean by 'valid' for the relevant arguments. Any argument that doesn't *have* any uniform interpretations will, vacuously, preserve truth on all uniform interpretations!
- Some evidence that the answer to Q2 is yes: '[Even] If John is robbing a bank, he shouldn't be robbing a bank'. '[Even] if John is [in fact] robbing a bank, he should be spending his life in Africa helping the poor'.
- Some evidence the answer to Q1 is yes: 'Either it's a donkey or it's likely to be a mule. There's a good chance that it's not a donkey. So, there's a good chance that it's likely to be a mule.'

A view where the answer to both questions is 'yes':

(i) Model *questions* as *partititions of logical space:* sets of propositions (the *answers* to the question) such that exactly one of them is true at each world. Yes-no questions are two-cell partitions.

(ii) At any point in a conversation certain questions are "under discussion". Utterance of a sentence generally puts under discussion both the yes-no question corresponding to the entire sentence, and the questions corresponding to its parts.

(iii) In general, every modal and conditional is associated with an accessibility relation.

(iv) Often (typically?), the accessibility relation for a modal or conditional uttered when certain questions Q_1, Q_2,… are under dicussion is *constrained by* Q_1, Q_2, … — i.e. it's such that for v to be accessible from w, v and w must belong to the same cell of Q_1, and belong to the same cell of Q_2, and…

- E.g.: 'I'm pretty confident that this coin might land Tails', said of a coin chosen from a bucket with many ordinary coins and some double-headed coins. QUD: 'Is the coin double headed?'
- When 'might' is constrained by the yes-no question 'A?', 'might P' is equivalent to '(A and might (A and P)) or (not-A and might (not-A and not P)).
- When 'if' is constrained by 'A?', 'if P, Q' is equivalent to '(A and if A and P, Q) or (not-A and if not-A and P, Q)'.

(v) When we are interpreting B in 'If A, B', or 'A or B' or 'A and B', the yes-no question corresponding to A will typically be under dicussion, and any modals that occur in B will be constrained by this question.

- When this happens, 'If A, might P' will be equivalent to 'If A, (A and might (A and P)) or (not-A and might (not-A and not P))', which is in turn logically equivalent to 'If A, might (A and P)'.
- 'If A, (if P, Q)' will be equivalent to 'If A, (A and if A and P, Q) or (not-A and if not-A and P, Q)', which is in turn logically equivalent to 'If A, (if A and P, Q)'.

2. Adverbial quantifiers versus nominal quantifiers

Adverbial:

(1) a. Always[/Mostly/Sometimes] if a student goofs off, he will fail
b . Always[/Mostly/Sometimes] a student will fail if he goofs off
c. Always[/Mostly/Sometimes] if a student goofed off, he failed
d. Always[/Mostly/Sometimes] a student failed if he goofed off

Nominal

(2) a. Every student[/no student] will fail if he goofs off
b. Most students[/some students] will fail if they goof off
c. Every student[/no student] failed if he goofed off
d. Most students[/some students] failed if they goofed off

What's the relation between these and

(3) a. Every student/no student who goofs off will fail
b. Most students/some students who goof off will fail
c. Every student/no student who goofed off failed
d. Most students/some students who goofed off failed

Kai von Fintel and Sabine Iatridou note a semantic difference between (2ab) and (3ab): (2b) could be true even if in fact it makes almost everyone work hard except for the teacher's pet who won't fail no matter what.

- Is there the same difference between (1ab) and (3ab)?

- Is there a similar difference between (2cd) and (3cd)?

Cases where an 'if' clause seems interchangeable with a normal relative clause:

(4) a. Every query was answered if it came from a reputable address.
  b. Every day, he went for a walk after lunch if he had time.
  c. Every participant chose A if given a choice between A and B.

(5) a. Every query which came from a reputable address was answered.
  b. Every day on which he had time, he went for a walk after lunch.
  c. Every participant who was given a choice between A and B chose A.

3. Syntactic high-jinks for 'if' under nominal quantifiers?

Could the logical form of (3c) be like this?

?? [Every [[student] [if he goofed off]]] [failed]

4. Read the conditional as material?

(6) a. No query went unanswered if it came from a reputable address.
  b. Most queries were answered if they came from a reputable address.

(7) a. No query which came from a reputable address went unanswered.
  b. Most queries which came from a reputable address were answered.

5. Appeal to contextual domain restriction?

(8) Every query was answered if it came from a reputable address and discarded if it came from a particularly disreputable address

(9) Every query which came from a reputable address was answered and every query which came from a particularly disreputable address was discarded

6. Can a domain restriction solution also work for adverbial quantifiers?

Adverbial quantiers are often restricted in a way that's influenced (pragmatically?) by material in the sentence:

(10) Tai always eats with chopsticks
(11) Officers always had lunch with ballerinas
(12) Leopards usually attack monkeys in trees